A Perfect Ganesh

By Terrence McNally

Characters: Katherine and Margaret (50s) two friends traveling together to India.
Scene: An airplane bound for India

INTRODUCTION

Katherine and Margaret are both traveling to India, in search of some kind of spiritual release; Katherine from the guilt she feels over her son's death and Margaret from the fear caused by a lump she has discovered in her breast. The two go back a long way, as can be seen in this scene where Katherine does her best to combat Margaret's fear of flying. A Perfect Ganesh by Terrence McNally.

KATHERINE: Does he remind you of Walter?

MARGARET: The steward? Not in the least.

KATHERINE: I didn't know you were afraid of flying.

MARGARET: I've flown over this part of the Atlantic this time of the year at least fifteen times and it was never like this.

KATHERINE: Actually, I like a little turbulence.

MARGARET: You're the type who would.

KATHERINE: It lets me know we're really up there. If it gets too quiet and still, I worry the engines have stopped and we're just going to plummet to the earth.

MARGARET: Can we talk about something else?

KATHERINE: Do you want to hold my hand?

MARGARET: Of course not.

KATHERINE: Do you want some gum?

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MARGARET: Is it the kind that sticks to your crowns?

KATHERINE: I don't know.

MARGARET: If it's the kind that sticks I don't want it.

KATHERINE: You're out of luck. It must have been in the bag I left in the terminal.

MARGARET: What's that?

KATHERINE: A whistle. George made me take it. In case we get in any sort of trouble in India, I'm supposed to blow it so help will come. "Who?" I asked him. "Sabu on an elephant?"

MARGARET: Will you keep your voice down? (The plane heaves, extra-mightily this time.)

KATHERINE: This is ridiculous. Give me your hand.

MARGARET: We're all going to die.

KATHERINE: Just shut up and say a "Hail, Mary."

MARGARET: Methodists don't say" Hail, Mary."

KATHERINE: We're going to be all right.

MARGARET: Ow! That's too tight! (The turbulence subsides.)

KATHERINE: See?

MARGARET: I can bear anything as long as I know it's going to end.

KATHERINE: Remember the last year we went to St. Kitt's?

MARGARET: The men got sick from eating crayfish.

KATHERINE: They were langouste.

MARGARET: They looked like crayfish.

KATHERINE: That's not the reason I never wanted to go back there.

MARGARET: Alan nearly died. Besides, it was a time for a new island.

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KATHERINE: It was the incident with the little plane.

MARGARET: What incident? I don't remember.

KATHERINE: Yes, you do. We were swimming in front of the hotel. A small, single-engine plane had taken off from the airport. The engine kept stalling. No one moved. It was terrifying. That little plane just floating there. No sound. No sound at all. Like a kite without a string. I don't think I've ever felt so helpless.

MARGARET: I remember.

KATHERINE: Finally, I guess the pilot made the necessary adjustments, the engine caught and stayed caught and the little plane flew away, as if nothing had happened, and we finished swimming and played tennis and after lunch you bought the Lalique vase I could still kick myself for letting you have.

MARGARET: You've envied me that piece of Lalique all these years? It's yours.

KATHERINE: I don't want it.

MARGARET: Really, I insist, Kitty. I think I only bought it because I knew you wanted it. That, and I was mad at Alan for some crack about how I looked in my new bathing suit. The plane's stopped jiggling. Smooth as glass now.

KATHERINE: I've thought about that little plane a lot. Maybe we were helpless. May be we weren't responsible. Maybe it wasn't our fault. But what kept that plane up there? God? A God? Some Benevolence? Prayer? Our prayers? I think everyone on that beach was praying that morning in their particular way. So maybe we aren't so

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helpless. Maybe we are responsible. Maybe it is our fault what happens. Maybe, maybe, maybe.

MARGARET: Do you want to give me my hand back?

KATHERINE: I'm sorry. Thank you. Did I do that? I was holding tight! I'm sorry. (She kisses Margaret's hand.) What happened to your liver spots? You used to have great big liver spots.

MARGARET: Will you keep your voice down? I keep begging you to come with me. The man's a genius. And it's paradise there.

KATHERINE: And it costs three thousand dollars a week. I'd rather go to India for my soul than some spa in Orange County for the backs of my hands.

MARGARET: Happily, you can afford both.

KATHERINE: I keep thinking about Walter.

MARGARET: Why would you do that to yourself?

KATHERINE: I can't help it.

MARGARET: Well, stop. Stop right now. Think about something else. Think about the Taj Mahal. Think about India.

KATHERINE: They say it's like a dream, the Taj Mahal.

MARGARET: I hope it's not like the Eiffel Tower. All your life you look at pictures of the Eiffel Tower and then when you actually see it, it looks just like the pictures of it. There's no resonance when you look at the Eiffel Tower. I'm expecting some resonance from the Taj Mahal. I'll be terribly disappointed if there isn't any. You're humming again, Kitty.

KATHERINE: I'm sorry.

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MARGARET: You asked me to tell you.

KATHERINE: All of a sudden, I can't remember when it was built!

MARGARET: It was begun in 1632 and completed in 1654.

KATHERINE: All that reading up on it and for what?

MARGARET: Do you remember who it was built for?

KATHERINE: Of course I do. Someone's wife.

MARGARET: Everyone knows that, Kitty. What was her name?

KATHERINE: I knew you were going to ask me that. Marilyn? Betty? Betty Mahal? I know who built it. Shah Jahan.

MARGARET: The favorite wife was Mumtaz Mahal.

KATHERINE: Mumtaz, of course! It was on the tip of my tongue.

MARGARET: It took twenty-two years and twenty thousand workers to build.

KATHERINE: Is this going to be some sort of pop quiz?

MARGARET: I was trying to get your mind off Walter.

KATHERINE: Nothing will ever get my mind off Walter.

MARGARET: This is a wonderful start to a trip!

KATHERINE: I'm sorry. (She hums a little.)

MARGARET: Kitty, sshh!, you're doing it. It's nobody's fault. (Katherine begins to read from a travel brochure she has taken out of her purse.)

KATHERINE: Now listen to this. (She reads.) "Don't drink the water, which means absolutely no ice in your drinks or eating of washed fruits and vegetables." Sounds charming. "Above all be patient. Allow, accept, be."

MARGARET: That's what I've been telling you.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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